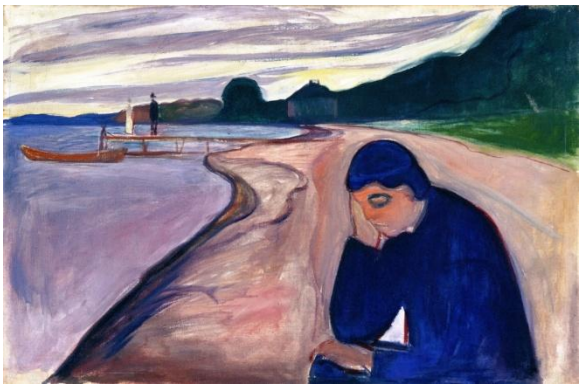
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Kant, Heidegger, and Munch in Oslo



Edvard Munch, *Melancholy*, 1893. Oil on Canvas.

My first semester of four-year college was spent abroad in the United Kingdom, this helped me revamp my European roots, meet with family and expand my worldview through a new cultural experience. I had the chance to travel, learn, and grow as an adult and human. This was a dramatic shift from my previous dynamic, being newly removed from support systems like close friends and family, in a near Faustian pursuit of knowledge and original experience. The lack of familiar expectations. I experienced a dorm of existential freedom which became a melancholy mix of overwhelming and liberating. Removed from previous structures I confronted Kant's call or intellectual maturity and Heidegger's anxiety in a world without solid grounding. Perhaps, it was this release into a blossoming frontier that pushed me towards interest in the concepts of which I will later divulge.

My act of freedom was independent travel, I was able to plan my weekends to travel on my own, or with my newfound roommates, to distant places on our own dime and volition. We impulsively planned many trips the week of for the weekends, we shared a group boy's trip to Oslo, Norway together. Booking flights, hostels, and packing our belongings into a singular shared suitcase. We made our own itinerary, mostly playing it by ear, moving between the sights and museums of Oslo. This experience expanded and enabled my sense of self; in style, art, and image; but also, an emotional sense of both excitement and uncertainty, vertigo, which I grappled with. This is shown in Norwegian painter Edvard Munch's painting *Melancholy* having to do more with relationships, the painting still shows someone experiencing a sense of anxiety around starting anew. Because most of my time there was dedicated to travel across the country and continent, allowing me a mature freedom which I could now obtain and use. However, despite the removal of self/societal imposed expectations of compliance (Kantian immaturity) in one sense, I was never truly free of all social barriers (money, school, relationships).

In his essay, "What is Enlightenment?" Kant defines "immaturity" as "…the inability to use one's understanding without guidance from another" (1). And therefore, he defines enlightenment as "Sapere Aude! ... '[to] Have courage to use your own understanding!'" (1). This daring to know displays the changes in my situation from living at home to abroad. While at home I lived partially under "guided immaturity" with established social expectations in family frameworks, presenting an established identity, as a member of the family, a brother, a son. In contrast while I was abroad, I had to navigate in maturity the establishment of a new identity within an unformed social dynamic. However, this also came with the benefit that I had no imposed thought, or inherited interpretation of the world, with no overarching figure correcting actions or beliefs (in Kant's interpretation: the tax man, prince, priest, and the 'rational' imposing

onto others) this self-ruledness, in my opinion could've only occurred abroad as Kant says "… for no one has ever allowed him to attempt it" (3). Meaning that connection to the aforementioned structures would have tainted a social maturity, "enlightenment". Kant says that You must legislate for yourself (1)., that You must choose rational principles (3)., that you cannot hide behind tradition (3). Because of freedom being defined in the Kantian sense as the obligation to self-govern, the act of 'mature' acts did not simply enable me to choose but rather require it. The weight of which produces anxiety, as Kant defines "treating men, *who are now more than machines*, in accord with their dignity." (12). And its newfound freedom.

In Heidegger's book *Being and Time*, he presents the concept of "the They" or "Das Man" as the collective norms, societal expectations, and an inherited way of living. I applied this in my familiar home, as mentioned above, where identity and expectations were socially inherited. While abroad these expectations weakened, where I became aware of myself as someone actively constructing my identity. This is defined in Heidegger through Dasein (being) becoming defined by anxiety in which someone meaningfully recognizes their own existence: "…Being, is anxiety. In this state-of-mind, Dasein finds itself face to face with the 'nothing' of the possible impossibility of its existence" (310). This is followed by categorizations of fear and anxiety in my life (found through Heidegger) as fear contains an object (i.e. fear of failing a class or getting lost) while anxiety proves deeper in Heidegger as its about the possibility pf self and the acceptance and contractionary denial of the upmost possibility of death. This anxiety spawns not from present physical danger but from a mental realization that there is no fixed path, guaranteed meaning, or predetermined self (unless you're a Calvinist /j). It reveals the existence stripped of normal (historical) certainty. I am fully confronted that my identity is reliant on

myself and created, and accepting the overwhelming openness and Heideggerian anxiety which it presents.

To characterize freedom and my emotions and anxiety around it, I have to dela with the psychological contradiction which it presents the core contradiction of my freedom was that before this I desired freedom, but once I was living it or attained this freedom the openness felt destabilizing, displaying a need for an invisible structure, which I would have to construct myself out of Kantian enlightenment, as without it any and all choices I make will feel amplified in its effects. When I was abroad all choices (whether monetary, social, academic) stopped feeling temporary or without consequence and began to feel like identity-forming pinnacles. Freedom became stressful as choices felt existentially meaningful, however my trip to Oslo displays a type of meaningful growth and enlightenment into lessening the weight of freedom on self-definition.

Kant presents that people avoid autonomy because dependence is psychologically comfortable. As in: “Laziness and cowardice are the reasons why so great a proportion of men… gladly remain in lifelong immaturity” (Kant 2). Denying comfort reveals the emotional cost of ‘enlightenment’ or autonomy. Along with Heidegger who presents that Anxiety individualizes. Through familiar social systems dissolve individuality into a cemented collective expectation, while I was abroad I was able to become radically aware of my separation from these systems, and enabled me to start forming my own, being “too free” did not mean unlimited happiness, but rather an inability to escape awareness of my personal responsibility. Freedom produced a reset, creating disorientation and type of social ‘loneliness’ which presents that you as an individual has to build their own relationship and social structures.

My unconscious realization and instinct in this matter was at first, not to immediately generate this radical authenticity, but rather to reconstruct one’s own stability in being. By

creating order when confronted by existential freedom, we confirm Kant in that we reject enlightenment, being rooted in comfort. Through the lens of Heidegger existential anxiety forced confrontation with adulthood and responsibilities, revealing its truth. By recognizing my life as genuinely in my control, it forced me to stop passively inheriting my identity and build my own interpretation. Kant's definition of enlightenment presents that the act is personally meaningful rather than abstract (societal). Kant's "courage" implies a certain uncertainty, risk, and possible failure within enlightenment, meaning that the act of recognizing and acting on one's freedom requires psychological determination and endurance, past the failure and lull of conformity.

In my time abroad, I did not eliminate Heidegger's "anxiety", but I did advance my own Kantian "enlightenment" learning to live more consciously of myself, my biases, and my ultimate decisions. Instead of ultimate freedom of *Wanderlust,* I was still confronted with responsibility placed solely on myself, with uncertainty becoming unavoidable rather than abnormal. Overall, this experience changed my understanding of freedom, that it is not merely a removal of restrictions; but the ongoing responsibility of constructing meaning without guaranteed certainty in being.



Photo in front of the Oslo Opera House, 2025. Digital.

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